



FITNESSWISE

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Builders of champions

Here's what goes into **shaping young athletes** beyond the scoreboard and why great coaching is about much more than just winning.

Helping players develop from amateurs to professionals is no mean task. Mostly, we see the end product, but what goes into the making of elite players is rarely acknowledged. Many may surge ahead while others may not even cross the school level, but the process remains the same. Let's look at what makes brilliant coaches stand out from the rest:

- They value the child over the athlete. They know that being an athlete is just a small part of being a child. Brilliant coaches certainly do not do anything to progress the athlete at the cost of the child.

- Treat all athletes with respect, even the kids in the training centre, on the field, court, etc., no matter what background they belong to.

- Connect with parents. Coaches understand that they are not the enemy and, in fact, are crucial collaborators in the development of the athlete.

- They hear their athletes' concerns. They seldom brush off their worries, fears, or injuries.

- Brilliant coaches understand the importance of emotional connection, making athletes feel more important as people than as athletes, which gives them deeper levels of engagement. Their most fundamental needs are safety and security.

- They know that this foundation of trust is essential. When a player feels safe, they can trust, and when they trust, they can learn.

- Begin with the long-term plan in mind. Keep the focus on the bigger picture of the athlete's goals. They have a plan but remain adaptable, as they are aware the road to success is filled with uncertainties.

- Coaches are obsessive about fundamentals. The brilliant ones understand the value of fundamentals as the core of all skills. The stronger the core, the more successful the athlete.

- **Break skills into portions. They don't simply teach a whole cartwheel; they break it into several key sub-skills and instruct those first by segregating the individual elements that are woven together to achieve the skill. Athletes tend to succeed faster this way.**

- Embrace athletes' struggles. They understand that learning is a process, much like muscles that need to break down before building up. A brilliant coach doesn't panic when this struggle happens — this is where growth occurs.

- Make the monotonous stimulating. When a coach connects the tedious to the goal and creates games out of repetitive drills, they instigate challenges and create purpose.

- Narrate corrections in a positive

mode. Brilliant coaches say "do this", not "don't do this." For example, to a bowler — "Don't bend your arms" is less effective feedback than "keep your arms straight."

- Find the bright spots and build from there. Brilliant coaches are aware of weaknesses and try to improve them to minimal standards but spend more focus on areas where an athlete excels and progresses.

- They give feedback in short, clear spurts that are precise and action-oriented, followed up with remedial measures.

- Be very careful in how they measure success. They do not use scores or win-loss records as their sole measure of success. They understand that doing so can erode long-term development. They focus on building competencies for the long run, even if it means sacrificing early success.

- Use the right mixture of achievable and challenging goals. Zone in on the sweet spot of challenge.

- Keep momentum moving forward, understanding that objects in motion stay in motion, so there is minimal wasted or idle time in practice.

- Many acknowledge that extraordinary talent is not a fair assessment of their value; rather, they measure their ability by helping